

MIG-15

Migrant Interview: Inclusion and Xenophobia

Interviewee Profile

Interview code: MIG-15

Age: 31

Gender: Female

Country of origin: Sudan

Host country: United Kingdom

Years in host country: 4

Occupation: Pharmacy Assistant

Interview

Q1. Can you tell me about your journey and what brought you to your host country?

A: I came to the United Kingdom four years ago, fleeing the conflict and instability in Sudan that made ordinary life increasingly dangerous and uncertain, with violence spreading and the future growing ever darker. My family sought safety above all, and also the chance for me to continue my education and my career in a place where such things were possible again. The journey to get here was long and arduous, full of difficulty and uncertainty, but I was absolutely determined to find a place where I could live without constant fear and begin to rebuild the life that the conflict had interrupted and threatened. Arriving safely, after everything, felt like being given a second chance that I was resolved not to waste, however hard the road ahead might prove.

Q2. What does 'inclusion' mean to you personally?

A: Inclusion means being accepted as a British Muslim woman, valued for my skills, my work, and my character rather than being judged and prejudged by my hijab or my origins the moment I am seen. It shows itself when I am given genuinely equal opportunities at work, the same chances to prove myself and to advance as anyone else, and when I am treated with basic respect and dignity in the course of ordinary daily life. Belonging, for me, is the feeling that I am genuinely part of this society, woven into it and accepted as one of its members, rather than merely being tolerated within it as an outsider whose presence is permitted but never fully welcomed.

Q3. Have you experienced xenophobia or discrimination? Can you describe it?

A: Yes, I face xenophobia, and in my case it is very often intertwined with both Islamophobia and racism, since I am a visibly Muslim Black woman, and these different prejudices overlap and compound one another in ways that are hard to disentangle. I have experienced hostile stares from strangers, pointed and unpleasant comments about my headscarf, and discrimination in the workplace that held me back or made me feel unwelcome. After certain events in the news, the general atmosphere becomes noticeably more hostile and tense for people who look like me. It is genuinely exhausting to have to constantly navigate these layers of prejudice in everyday situations, to brace oneself for hostility in the most ordinary encounters.

Q4. What have been the biggest challenges in adapting to your new country?

A: The main challenges were the trauma of leaving a conflict zone, which does not simply disappear once you reach safety but stays with you, combined with the complex and often bewildering immigration process and the difficulty of adjusting to a very different culture and a much colder climate. Getting my existing qualifications recognised here was difficult and slow, which forced me to start at a lower professional level than my education and experience really warranted, a real source of frustration. And finding genuine acceptance as a visibly Muslim woman, in a society where that visibility can attract suspicion and hostility, added another significant and wearing layer of difficulty to everything else I was already trying to manage.

Q5. How would you describe your experience in the workplace or professional environment?

A: My pharmacy workplace is fairly diverse, which helps a great deal, and the majority of my colleagues are professional, decent, and kind, treating me as a valued member of the team. There are occasional uncomfortable moments, of course, but overall I feel genuinely respected for my work ethic, my reliability, and my competence, which is what I most want to be judged on. Building trust and rapport with the regular customers, who come over time to know me, to appreciate my help and advice, and to treat me warmly, has been one of the most rewarding and affirming parts of my job here, and it has helped me feel that I do belong and that I am valued for what I contribute.

Q6. How do you balance maintaining your cultural identity with integrating into the host society?

A: I hold my Sudanese and Muslim identity close and dear through my faith, which anchors and sustains me through every difficulty, through my language, through traditional food that connects me to home, and through my connections to the community here who share my background and understand my experience. At the same time, I have genuinely embraced many aspects of British life and its values, integrating and participating while remaining entirely true to myself and my beliefs. I feel proudly Sudanese and increasingly British at once, and I firmly refuse to see my faith and my new home as being in any way incompatible; I am both, fully, and I insist on the right to be so without apology or compromise.

Q7. How do you feel the media portrays migrants from your background?

A: British media too often portrays Muslims and African refugees in relentlessly negative terms, linking us to extremism and violence or portraying us as burdens on the state and its resources, rarely acknowledging our contributions or our humanity. This kind of coverage directly and measurably worsens the prejudice I face in my daily life, shaping how strangers regard me before a single word passes between us. The everyday reality of Muslim women contributing productively to British society as pharmacists, doctors, nurses, teachers, and professionals of every kind is very rarely shown or acknowledged. This persistent imbalance in what stories get told shapes how strangers perceive and treat me, and it is deeply unfair.

Q8. Have integration programs or community support been helpful in your experience?

A: Refugee support in the UK has diminished significantly over the years I have been aware of it, cut back under successive governments, and I relied heavily on charities and community groups for practical help with settling in, finding my feet, and understanding the systems around me. The official

support available was minimal and heavily bureaucratic, difficult to access and impersonal in its operation. The organisations run by and for refugees themselves were by far the most helpful to me, precisely because they understood our specific needs and experiences in ways that generic government programmes consistently failed to grasp, offering not just services but genuine understanding and solidarity when I needed both.

Q9. How has the next generation (or younger migrants) adapted compared to you?

A: I hope that any children I may have in the future will grow up proud of their Sudanese heritage and their Muslim faith while also thriving fully as British citizens, holding both parts of their identity without conflict, shame, or a sense of having to choose. I have watched the children of other African and Muslim immigrants excel here academically and professionally, achieving impressive things, even as they navigate the realities of discrimination and questions about their belonging. My hope is that the next generation will encounter a more accepting and less prejudiced Britain than the one I currently have to navigate, one where their background is simply part of who they are rather than a barrier or a source of suspicion.

Q10. In your opinion, what would help reduce xenophobia in society?

A: To reduce xenophobia, honest and thorough education about Islam, about Africa, and about the real reasons that people are compelled to seek refuge is essential in order to counter the distortions and stereotypes that the media so often spreads. Political leaders bear a heavy responsibility to stop demonising migrants and refugees for political gain, because that rhetoric does lasting harm. And personal relationships are genuinely transformative, in my experience the single most powerful force for change; when people actually come to know a Muslim woman personally, as a colleague or a neighbour or a friend, their fearful assumptions and prejudices tend to dissolve. Real human connection is the strongest antidote there is to prejudice and hatred, far stronger than any argument.

Q11. What are your hopes and dreams for the future?

A: I hope to requalify fully and to advance into a complete pharmacist role, using my skills and knowledge to serve the community and to reach the professional level that my training and ambition point toward. I want to mentor and support other refugee women who are facing the same barriers and challenges that I have had to overcome, so that their path might be a little easier than mine was. And, looking beyond my own life, I dream of a peaceful and stable Sudan, and of building a secure, dignified, and flourishing life here in Britain where my family can thrive in safety and without fear, free from the dangers we fled.

Q12. What advice would you give to new migrants arriving in your host country?

A: My advice to newcomers is to stay resilient and to never internalise the prejudice of others, because your inherent worth and dignity do not depend in any way on how others choose to see or treat you. Pursue education and requalification persistently and patiently, even when the process is slow and discouraging, because it is worth it in the end. Actively seek out supportive communities and the charities that understand your situation, because you should not face these challenges alone. Preserve your faith and your identity proudly while engaging openly with your new society. And, above all, let your contributions and your character speak louder than any stereotype ever could.